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by MICHAEL RAYNER

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GOOD WEEKEND

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INSIDE STORIES

THE GENERALS AND ADMIRALS OPEN THE DOOR TO CIVILIANS

By KEITH DUNSTAN

THERE IS trouble everywhere in club land. Members are not eating and drinking with the devotion they had of old. But perhaps the biggest sufferers of all are the military clubs. Where now do they go for members?

The returned men from World War II are 60 years or over and they are not showing the old passion for a game of squash, half-a-dozen beers on the way home or lunch with the boys.

The Korean War gave an infusion of new members. The Vietnam War gave another bonus but not nearly enough. The time has come when these clubs desperately need another war to keep them in the old style.

The Imperial Service Club in Sydney has lost half its members since 1972 and its amalgamation with the Royal Automobile Club is expected to be finalised before Christmas. The Naval & Military Club in Melbourne also has had to make some tough decisions. One feels for the old N&M.

I always thought it was one of the best of all clubs. It is now 104 years old. Unquestionably the most noble of its premises was 7 Alfred Place, just off Collins Street.

Back before World War I ironically it was the German Club. So when the Germans dropped hideously out of favour the conquerors took over the building.

The great dining room was one of the best three or four rooms in all Melbourne. The staircase was the type that had a true sense of grandeur. Right at the top they had a vast portrait of King George V and it was all so awesome you felt almost that you had to go up the stairs towards His Majesty on your knees.

Of course, you had to be a commissioned officer to be a member and at the club an officer always remained an officer.

When they called you for the telephone, military rank always was announced.

Officers of the RAAF, the junior service, were admitted and tolerated but they never made it to the title. The military members who had the numbers felt it would be too cumbersome to call it

the Naval and Military and Air Force Club. It was the tradition for a great admiral, general or air force knight to be the president. Field Marshal Sir Thomas Blamey was president and General Sir John Monash was president for more than a decade. Sir Thomas or Sir John had his own imposing presidential chair and to be invited to sit nearby was



The N&M Club: open to civilians

heaven. After World War II the club was so flush with members it felt it should move on to larger quarters. There was terrible agony over that decision, many felt clubs should remain atmospheric, stately and ancient.

But the modernists won the day and in 1964 they sold it. George Frew turned it into a tavern. He bricked up the squash court and did his best to turn it into an Edwardian curio.

Now it is very up-market as Mietta's restaurant.

The club built new quarters at the top of Little Collins Street, close to the ladies' Lyceum Club and the back of the Melbourne Club. It provided accommodation, splendid room for private parties and functions and the lunches became famous with a quite marvellous smorgasbord.

The smorgasbord was an eat as much as you like for a fixed price, hot or cold. They had Virginia hams, turkeys, vast slabs of roast beef, Stilton cheeses. It was always fascinating to observe portly majors, largish lieutenant commanders, group captains no end, assaulting the sweets.

I never saw the like; they would blow your mind and stomach ... apple pie